

The Lost Little Aurora

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two thoughtful ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, dreams up ideas, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being brave and kind and full of ideas, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.*

Before you begin

In the deep of winter the night grows long in the fjords, and the long night is meant to be the most beautiful time of all. High above the snow, the Aurora Spirits dance, and the whole sky ripples with teal and green and purple light. But on this particular evening, the sky stayed dark and still, as if it had forgotten how to shine.

There was a reason. The littlest Aurora Spirit had tumbled down out of the sky and fallen into the snowy Whispering Pines, and in her fall she had lost her colours. Now she huddled somewhere among the dark trees, far too shy and far too cold to glow, and without her the others would not dance.

Edda the Saga-Keeper called the two of you in from the cold, to the firelight of the Hearth Hall. "You have bright ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more on a night like this than any sword. Will you go into the pines and help the little aurora shine again?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a little lantern to light your way, a ball of bright red yarn, and a honey bun still warm from the hearth. "Remember," she said, "up here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Heart?*

Stop 1 The Dark Forest

You stepped out under the dark sky and into the Whispering Pines. The snow lay deep and soft and hushed, and the tall trees rose around you, still and quiet, with the wind carrying soft voices through their branches. Somewhere in all this stillness, one tiny aurora was hiding, shy and cold and no bigger than a pair of cupped hands.

She would be easy to miss. You would have to move gently and look with care.

★ *How will you find her? You might walk softly and watch for the faintest glimmer of light, or follow small footprints pressed into the snow. Nori the Tomte, the red-capped hearth sprite, is somewhere nearby, and he loves to help. What do you try?*

When you slowed right down and looked kindly into the shadows, you caught it: a soft, trembling glimmer behind a pine trunk. There she was, the littlest aurora, dim and shivering and very pleased to be found. "Hello," you whispered. "We came to help you." And she crept out to meet you.

Stop 2 The Three Colours

The little aurora was glad beyond words to be found, but try as she might, she could not make herself glow. "I lost my three colours when I fell," she said, and her voice was small. "Teal, and green, and purple. They slipped away into the world, and I cannot shine without them."

But the colours had not gone far at all. Each one was hiding somewhere close, in a thing that wore that very colour, if only you knew where to look.



Can you find all three of her colours? Where in this snowy place might teal be hiding? Where green? Where purple? Think of the icicles, the pines, and the wide evening sky.

You found her teal in the heart of a shining icicle, her green in the deep needles of a pine branch, and her purple high up where the twilight sky was turning dark. One colour at a time, you helped her draw each one back into herself, and one colour at a time, the little aurora began to glow, soft and warm and brighter every moment.

Stop 3 The Climb to the Sky

She glowed now, gentle and lovely, but when she looked up at the great dark sky her light wavered. "It is so very high," she said. "What if I cannot reach it? What if I fall all over again?" Being found was one thing. Rising back up into the night was quite another, and she was afraid.

She did not need to be braver than her fear. She only needed a little courage borrowed from friends, and a hand to help her up.



How will you help her find her courage? You might climb the tallest pine beside her, cheer her on from below, or use the ball of red yarn to give her a gentle boost up into the air. What is your plan?

You climbed the tallest pine, branch by snowy branch, and tied the red yarn so she had something to hold. Then you counted together, one, two, three, and called out, "You can do it, we believe in you!" The little aurora drew a deep breath, let go of the topmost bough, and leapt up into the dark.

The Sky Dances Again

Up she went, and up, glowing brighter with every length she rose, until the other Aurora Spirits came swooping down to meet her, laughing and singing, "You came back! You came back to us!" They gathered her in among them as if she had never been gone.

And then the whole sky woke. Teal and green and purple spilled across the night and began to dance, ribbon over ribbon, swirling above the snowy fjord and the warm amber windows of the longhouses below. The long night was dark no longer, and all the fjords looked up in wonder.

High among the stars, Freya the Kind looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your ideas, with your courage, and above all with your heart. Well done, heroes of the Snowlit Fjords of the North.

The Lost Little Aurora: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale, soft and warm, where good ideas and kindness win every time and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Hearth Hall.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a small light or token for the little lantern, a ball of red string for the red yarn, and any small thing at all for the honey bun. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Heart together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these fjords, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
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1	Nori the Tomte pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A friendly wind off the fjord, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Two Ravens fly over and nod kindly. All is well.
5	A lucky strand of red yarn: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of warmth from the hearth, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The little aurora is too shy and too cold to glow, but she is no villain and there is no foe in this tale at all. It is won not by beating anyone but by finding her, helping her gather her three colours, and lending her the courage to leap back into the sky. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Lost Little Aurora: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Dark Forest (Easy)

The challenge. The littlest Aurora Spirit is hiding among the snowy pines, shy and cold and very small. The players must find her without frightening her away.

Intended solution. This is a moment for Observation and Heart. The thoughtful, kind move is to slow down and look gently: watch for the faint glimmer of her light, follow small footprints in the snow, and speak softly so she is not scared. Asking **Nori the Tomte**, the red-capped hearth sprite, for a hint works just as well.

Fallback. If the children cannot spot her, have her own light flicker for a moment behind a particular tree, or let Nori peek out and point with a wink. The gentlest look or the kindest word brings her out; any honest attempt to find her counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: The Three Colours (Normal)

The challenge. The little aurora has lost her three colours, teal, green and purple, and cannot glow until the players help her gather them back. Each colour is hiding in something in the world that wears it.

Intended solution. This is an Observation and Logic moment. The good idea is to match each colour to the world around them: **teal** from a shining icicle, **green** from a dark pine branch, and **purple** from the deepening twilight sky. Naming any sensible source of each colour works; the point is matching colour to thing, not one single correct object.

Fallback. If they are stuck on a colour, let the little aurora glance hopefully toward the right place ("an icicle catches her eye"), or have Nori hum and tip his head at it. Each colour found makes her glow a little brighter, and finding them with help still counts in full.

Stop 3: The Climb to the Sky (Normal)

The challenge. The little aurora glows again, but she is afraid to rise. She fears the sky is too high and that she will only fall once more. The players must help her find the courage to climb a tall pine and leap back up.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Courage moment. Any warm encouragement works: climbing the tallest pine alongside her, cheering her on, counting her up to the leap, or using the **red yarn** to give her a gentle boost up into the air. When the children lend her their courage, she takes a breath and leaps.

Fallback. If she hesitates, or the children are unsure how to help, have her ask quietly, "Will you count with me?" A single kind, brave word is enough. The moment the players cheer her on in any way at all, she gathers herself and rises.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the little aurora leaps back into the sky, the other **Aurora Spirits** swoop down to welcome her home, and the whole night sky dances with teal, green and purple over the snowy fjord. High among the stars, **Freya the Kind** smiles down. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.